

Domain Name Research

Research Questions

What is an internet domain name? A domain name is the human-readable address used to find a website on the internet (for example, example.com). Behind the scenes, every device on the internet is identified by a numeric IP address, but those strings of numbers are hard for people to remember. The domain name system (DNS) translates easy-to-remember names into the IP addresses computers actually use to locate servers.

Why are domain names so important on the web? A domain name is essentially a website's identity and address. It's how visitors find a site, how a brand or person presents themselves online, and how email and other services are tied to an organization. A short, memorable, relevant domain name makes a site easier to find, share, and trust, and it plays a role in branding and search visibility.

Why do domain names have to be unique? Because a domain name maps to a specific location (IP address) on the internet, no two entities can hold the exact same domain name within the same top-level domain (TLD) at the same time otherwise the DNS wouldn't know which server to send a visitor to. Uniqueness is enforced by central registries, which is why ICANN makes sure IP addresses and domains are unique so duplicates can be avoided.

What does it mean to "register" a domain name? Registering a domain name means paying a registrar (an accredited company) to reserve and lease that name for a set period of time, usually one year at a time. Domain names are leased on a yearly basis, not bought outright, and the registrant must renew the registration periodically or risk losing the name. Upon registration, the registrant enters into a contract with the registrar that describes the terms under which the registrar agrees to register and maintain the requested name.

If you wanted a domain name that is already taken, how could you get it? A few options exist:

- Check if the domain is simply "parked" or unused and contact the current owner (found via a WHOIS lookup) to ask if they'd sell it.
- Buy it on the secondary/aftermarket through a domain marketplace (e.g., a registrar's "make an offer" feature or a domain broker).
- Wait for it to expire if the current owner doesn't renew, the domain eventually becomes available again for registration.
- Choose a different TLD (e.g., .net, .org, .dev) or a slightly modified version of the name if the exact .com isn't available.
- In cases involving trademark infringement or cybersquatting, pursue a formal dispute process through ICANN's Uniform Domain-Name Dispute-Resolution Policy (UDRP).

How Domain Names Are Created and Registered

The domain name system is overseen globally by ICANN (Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers), a non-profit that coordinates domain names, IP addresses, and DNS. ICANN accredits registrars so they can offer domains to register, and oversees the Registry, Registrar, and Registrant relationship.

Key players in the process:

- **Registry** – manages a specific top-level domain (TLD), such as .com or .org, maintaining the master database of names registered under it.
- **Registrar** – an ICANN-accredited company (like Namecheap, GoDaddy, or Cloudflare) that sells domain registrations to the public and communicates changes back to the registry.
- **Registrant** – the individual or organization that registers and "leases" the domain name.

Steps to Get Your Own Domain Name

1. Brainstorm a name that fits your brand/personal project short, memorable, and easy to spell.
2. Use a registrar's search tool to check if your desired name (and TLD) is available.
3. If available, choose a TLD (.com, .net, .me, etc.) and add it to your cart.
4. Decide whether to add WHOIS/privacy protection (many registrars now include this for free).
5. Create an account with the registrar and complete checkout/payment.
6. Once registered, you can connect the domain to a web host (point its DNS records to your site's server) so it actually displays your website.
7. Renew the domain before it expires (typically annually) to keep ownership.

Registrar Companies and Pricing (2026)

Registrar	Approx. .com Price (first year)	Renewal Price	Notes
Spaceship (Namecheap-owned)	~\$4.99 promo	\$9.98/year for .com registration and renewal below wholesale	Modern UX, no upsells

Cloudflare Registrar	\$10.46/year for .com with zero markup	Same as registration	At-cost, no markup
Namecheap	\$11.28 standard, with a \$6.79 promo for new customers	Renews closer to \$18.48	Free WHOIS privacy, beginner-friendly
Porkbun	\$11.08 renewal	Same	Friendly interface, good support
NameSilo	\$11.05 with discount program	Similar	Good for bulk/multiple domains
GoDaddy	Low promo prices (often under \$1)	Higher renewal, around \$20+ for .com	Note: GoDaddy is no longer broadly recommended after a February 2026 ToS change that reclassified customers as "Business Customers" and removed certain consumer protections

Takeaway: First-year promo prices are often very low (sometimes under \$1), but the renewal price is what matters long-term. Registrars like Spaceship, Cloudflare, and Porkbun offer more consistent pricing between year one and renewals.

Sources Used

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3. nslookup.io "How does domain name registration work?": <https://www.nslookup.io/learning/how-does-domain-name-registration-work/>
4. GoDaddy Help "What is the difference between a registry, registrar and registrant?": <https://www.godaddy.com/help/what-is-the-difference-between-a-registry-registrar-and-registrant-8039>
5. Hostinger "8 best domain registrars in 2026: Tested & compared": <https://www.hostinger.com/tutorials/best-domain-registrars>
6. domainedetails.com "Best Domain Registrars Compared (2026)": <https://domainedetails.com/kb/getting-started/best-domain-registrars-compared>
7. namesilo.com "Cheapest Domain Registrars 2026: 5-Year Total Cost Compared"

My PWP Domain Name Choice(s) and Availability

[NOTE: Replace the placeholder below with your actual chosen name and check availability yourself on a registrar's search tool e.g., Namecheap.com, Spaceship.com, or Porkbun.com since availability changes constantly and I can't check it live for you.]

- **First choice:** yourname.com (*check availability*)
- **Second choice (backup):** yournameportfolio.com or yourname.dev (*check availability*)

To check: go to a registrar's homepage, type your desired name into the search bar, and it will instantly show whether the .com (and other TLD) versions are available, along with the price.